SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #12 · HOLY SPIRIT

# “If the Spirit were in me, I would never struggle.”

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## Where it often comes from

Testimonies that made the Christian life sound like instant, total victory. Being told that struggling with sin, sadness, or fear proves a lack of faith. Comparing your inner battles with how calm other Christians seem on Sunday. Perfectionism that says growth should be complete by now. Shame over a habit you have prayed about many times.

## What Scripture teaches

The struggle itself can be a sign that the Spirit is at work. Before Christ, sin often feels normal; with the Spirit, the flesh and the Spirit are at war. Paul himself described doing what he did not want to do. Growth is a lifelong process in which God works in you, and the Spirit helps you in your weakness, even when you do not know how to pray.

> *“So I say, walk by the Spirit, and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh. For the flesh craves what is contrary to the Spirit, and the Spirit what is contrary to the flesh. They are opposed to each other, so that you do not do what you want”* **(Galatians 5:16–17)**.

## Also see

> “I know that nothing good lives in me, that is, in my flesh; for I have the desire to do what is good, but I cannot carry it out. For I do not do the good I want to do. Instead, I keep on doing the evil I do not want to do” **(Romans 7:18–19)**.

> “Therefore, my beloved, just as you have always obeyed, not only in my presence, but now even more in my absence, continue to work out your salvation with fear and trembling. For it is God who works in you to will and to act on behalf of His good purpose” **(Philippians 2:12–13)**.

> “In the same way, the Spirit helps us in our weakness. For we do not know how we ought to pray, but the Spirit Himself intercedes for us with groans too deep for words” **(Romans 8:26)**.

> “Now we have this treasure in jars of clay to show that this surpassingly great power is from God and not from us” **(2 Corinthians 4:7)**.

## Common self-statements

- Real Christians don’t struggle like this.
- If I still fight this, the Spirit must not be in me.
- Everyone else has victory but me.
- I should be past this by now.
- My struggle proves I’m a fake.
- God must be giving up on me.

## Common logical errors

- **All-or-nothing thinking:** Believing you are either completely victorious or not a Christian at all.
- **Should statements:** “I should never feel tempted, sad, or afraid.”
- **Comparison:** Comparing your inner struggles with other people’s outer appearance.

- **Disqualifying the positive:** Ignoring that your desire to change is itself evidence of the Spirit.
- **Overgeneralization:** Turning “I struggle in this area” into “nothing has changed in me.”

## Challenging questions

- Did Paul, filled with the Spirit, still describe struggling?
- Would I even care about this struggle if the Spirit were not in me?
- Is growth an event or a lifelong process?
- Am I comparing my insides with other people’s outsides?
- What has changed in me since I came to Christ, even a little?
- Does Scripture promise no struggle, or help in the struggle?
- Who does Philippians 2:13 say is working in me?

## Truth summary

> Struggling does not mean the Spirit is absent. The battle between my flesh and the Spirit is part of the Christian life, and my desire to do right is a sign of His work in me. God is working in me to will and to act, and the Spirit helps me in my weakness. I am growing, not finished.

## Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Holy Spirit
- Temptation
- Weakness
- Sinful Nature
- Strength

## Listen: Overcoming Depression

**Overcoming Depression** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

*Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”*

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# My Plan for Replacing "If the Spirit were in me, I would never struggle"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

**Name:** _____ **Date started:** _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it now so you can see your progress later.*

**"If the Spirit were in me, I would never struggle."** I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

## 2 My best question

*The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.*

- ☐ Did Paul still struggle while filled with the Spirit?
- ☐ Would I care about this if the Spirit weren't in me?
- ☐ Is growth an event or a lifelong process?
- ☐ Am I comparing my insides to others' outsides?
- ☐ What has changed in me, even a little?
- ☐ Does God promise no struggle, or help in it?

**My own question:** _____

## 3 My replacement truth

*The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.*

- ☐ My struggle can be a sign the Spirit is at work.
- ☐ God is working in me to will and to act.
- ☐ The Spirit helps me in my weakness.
- ☐ I am growing, not finished.
- ☐ God's power shows up in jars of clay like me.
- ☐ I can walk by the Spirit one step at a time.

**In my own words:** _____

## 4 My Scripture

*The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.*

- [ ] **Galatians 5:16–17**
  *"So I say, walk by the Spirit, and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh. For the flesh craves what is contrary to the Spirit, and the Spirit what is contrary to the flesh. They are opposed to each other, so that you do not do what you want."*
- [ ] **Romans 7:18–19**
  *"I know that nothing good lives in me, that is, in my flesh; for I have the desire to do what is good, but I cannot carry it out. For I do not do the good I want to do. Instead, I keep on doing the evil I do not want to do."*
- [ ] **Philippians 2:12–13**
  *"Therefore, my beloved, just as you have always obeyed, not only in my presence, but now even more in my absence, continue to work out your salvation with fear and trembling. For it is God who works in you to will and to act on behalf of His good purpose."*
- [ ] **Romans 8:26**
  *"In the same way, the Spirit helps us in our weakness. For we do not know how we ought to pray, but the Spirit Himself intercedes for us with groans too deep for words."*
- [ ] **2 Corinthians 4:7**
  *"Now we have this treasure in jars of clay to show that this surpassingly great power is from God and not from us."*

**A verse I found myself:** _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# Practicing the Truth

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## 5 My practice plan

*Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.*

### EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

### PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Growth log:** Each day, write one small way I chose the Spirit's way over the flesh, or one way I asked for His help.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Romans 8:26 becomes: "In the same way, the Spirit helps **Sarah** in **her** weakness. For **she** does not know how **she** ought to pray, but the Spirit Himself intercedes for **her** with groans too deep for words."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Weakness" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

## 6 My action step this week

*Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.*

- ☐ **Write a "then and now" list:** three ways you think, act, or feel differently than before you knew Christ.
- ☐ **When the struggle comes, pause for one minute** and pray, "Spirit, help me right now," then take one small right step.
- ☐ **Read Romans 7:14–8:2 aloud,** noticing how Paul moves from struggle to "no condemnation."
- ☐ **Tell one trusted Christian about a struggle,** and ask them honestly whether they struggle too.

**What I will do:** _____

**When:** _____

**What the lie predicts will happen:** _____

## 7 End-of-week check-in

*Bring this page to your next session.*

**What actually happened:** _____

What I learned: _____

**The lie** "If the Spirit were in me, I would never struggle": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

## Daily practice tracker

| Day | Read my card | Said my verse | Used my reminder | One step I took with the Spirit's help |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | |
| Tue | | | | |
| Wed | | | | |
| Thu | | | | |
| Fri | | | | |
| Sat | | | | |
| Sun | | | | |

## My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If the Spirit were in me, I would never struggle.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

*Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.*

## Prayer

*Holy Spirit, thank You for living in me even when I struggle. Help me reject the lie that my battles prove You are absent. Help me in my weakness, strengthen me to walk in Your ways, and remind me that God is still working in me. I trust You to finish what You started. In Jesus' name, Amen.*

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*Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.*